Indeed, in a meeting of the Eastern Committee on 19 December 1918 there seemed little enthusiasm for Britain extending its involvement in Persia. Curzon opened the discussion with an explanation of the state of affairs there:

We are face to face, in the first place, with a country, the Government of which is weak and incompetent, the ruling classes corrupt and extortionate, the monarch worthless and the lower classes in a deplorable condition intellectually, physically and materially. Persia would be bankrupt if it were not for our money, and she would at this moment be in a state of revolution if it were not for our troops.[61]

If Curzon was trying to gain some sympathy for the Persian cause, his plan backfired. Instead, it led Montagu to question the very basis of Britain's involvement there, wondering aloud if the country had ever actually been left to its own devices, free of foreign support. Curzon's response – that such a move would be impossible, since there was no one within Persia capable of running that country properly without foreign aid – led Cecil to ask simply what would be the consequences should Persia be allowed to sink into chaos. Cecil then declared himself in favour of giving up entirely on Persia, including stopping all subsidies and supplies of arms. Sir Hamilton Grant (Foreign Secretary of the Indian government) argued that a certain level of anarchy in Persia would not be disastrous for India. As long as no other foreign power was able to gain a dominant position there, the Indian government cared little for the internal issues of Persia. For his part, Montagu believed that there was something to be said for letting Persia fall so far that it would come to realise, of its own accord, its need for Britain's assistance.

Clearly, Curzon's attempt to galvanise his colleagues into action over Persia was not working. Curzon's scaremongering was also countered by the presence at the meeting of Marling, the recalled minister for Tehran. Marling flatly denied that Bolshevism was the threat to Persia that Cox and Curzon so adamantly claimed it to be. Cecil also expressed his doubt that